case that Beijing simply expects governments around the Pacific to adopt "socialism with Chinese characteristics" or that Tokyo looks to help install parliamentary democracy. Rather, it is a more fundamental question of how each state is viewed by its neighbors and how much influence each state may have in the region thanks to perceptions of its national strength, governmental effectiveness, social dynamism, and opportunities provided by its system. From this perspective, the two are competing for regional authority, each pitting its political leadership against the other in making what Chinese scholar Yan Xuetong calls "strategic credibility" the litmus test for their influence.[22] This competition has been particularly active since 2012, when both Xi Jinping and Shinzo Abe came to power, each the most powerful national leader in decades.

It should be acknowledged that attempting to identify models of national development is an extremely subjective approach, and the evidence for determining which of the two countries is more influential will likely be more anecdotal, inferential, and indirect than explicitly discoverable. Nor is this question of serving as a model for other nations the same as the ubiquitous concept of soft power. Soft power is usually defined as an element of national power—specifically, the attractiveness of a particular system in creating the conditions through which that state can achieve policy goals. While both Beijing and Tokyo are undoubtedly interested in advancing their state interests, that is a question distinct from how each is viewed and what benefits each derives from the policies they pursue.[23]

The postwar period in Asian development divides neatly at roughly 1990, when Japan's economic "bubble" burst and China's reform policy was revitalized and its takeoff began.[24] For decades, Japan was the standard for development in Asia, but long gone are the days when a Mahathir Mohamad could declare Japan a role model for Malaysia and when even China considered Japan's modernization model a paradigm. Tokyo's hopes to leverage its economic ties with Southeast Asia, the so-called Flying Geese model, into broader political influence were derailed by China's rise in the 1990s.[25] Because Beijing is the largest